teams in Europe. There have been one or two teams that United seem to have played over and over again in the last ten years. I'm thinking of Barcelona, Juventus and Bayern Munich, in particular. It's almost as if you have to meet those teams in the Champions League just to find out what kind of progress you've made on the European stage.

In the autumn of 1996, I remember we got beaten twice by Juve, 1–0 both home and away. No matter how much of the ball we had, we just couldn't workout how to defeat them. We still qualified from the first group stage, though, and it felt for a while like we were on our way. There was one amazing night at Old Trafford when we spanked Porto 4–0 in the quarter-finals. That was the start, I think, of people taking United seriously as a team that could win the competition. That year, we went into the semi-finals against Borussia Dortmund believing we had a real chance. Instead, they mugged us: like so many German teams, they were very organized and knew exactly what they were doing. They defended really well; I remember their left-back, Jorg Hein-rich, was about as difficult to play against over those two games as any player I've ever faced. After they beat us 1–0 in the first leg in Dortmund, we fancied our chances, but they repeated that score line at Old Trafford and then went on to beat Juventus in the final.

Those games against Dortmund were real killers but, otherwise, things couldn't have gone much better for me that season. I found myself wearing the number 10 shirt, playing almost every game, and scoring the kind of goals I used to when playing for Ridgeway Rovers: like the one from beyond the halfway line at Selhurst Park against Wimbledon, or the volley against Chelsea at Stamford Bridge on the day I first met Victoria. To top it all off, I was voted PFA Young Player of the Year. When the opponents you're up against in the Premiership every week give you that kind of recognition, you can't help but feel like you're doing something right.

It was a great time to be a United player. We had the best manager in the country, and it definitely felt like we had the best number two as well. I know the boss said some uncomplimentary things about Brian Kidd after he left Old Trafford to take the manager's job at Blackburn Rovers, but I thought they made a great team. Kiddo's a fantastic coach—just ask anybody who's ever worked with him—and I think, at United especially, he did a great job working between the boss and the players. Everybody in the dressing room thought that Brian was 'one of us'. After training or after a game, no one needed to watch what they were saying or doing. Kiddo would be having a laugh along with the rest.